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Comprehensive Exams

Doctor of Education

Higher Education - Technology and Learning

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QUESTION 2

A. Accepting the premise that leadership is primarily associated with human behavior:

1. Describe the historical development and evolution of leadership in the literature of educational research
2. Give examples of how these theories have impacted modern management and leadership practices.

B. Assume that you have been assigned to create new/effective leadership teams in your organization.

1. Describe the processes and practices you would use from examples you described in Part A to create and manage these new teams.

Remember to include bibliography of sources cited in your answer in APA format.

The maximum length for Question 2 is 10 pages, excluding references.

Question 2

The historical development and evolution of leadership in the literature of educational research

Leadership teachings of the past decade and the last century have offered a great deal of advice from many perspectives on how best to build an organization for today. From their successes and failures, they have provided many important lessons for today's leadership and will continue to shape future leadership. Today's leadership role shifts from a group leadership model to one that places much more responsibility and accountability in individuals' hands. The work mode of the future will be more individual-centered than group-centered, with considerable self-determination and higher levels of shared-goal collaboration (Bieber et al., 2002).

Historically, leadership has evolved for centuries. In the era of Spencer's "Social Darwinism" (Marion, 2002, p. 194), the opening years of the 20th century represented the dawn of a new age, when the old world gave way to the new that started the Industrial Revolution during the major paradigm shifts in technology, socio-economic, and cultural change. The revolution spurred factory workers and their machines to do more. As a result, the Machine theory emerged (Marion, 2002, p. 21). Frederick Taylor, the Industrialist, considered the father of Scientific Management, in his famous handbook *Principles of Scientific Management* (1911) argued the theory that management's job was to identify the best way to train workers and to provide the supervision and monitoring needed to ensure that they would follow the prescribed methods (DuFour & Eaker, 1998, p. 20).

Modern organizational theory is rooted in Scientific Management and the human relations approach. It deals with the formal structure, internal workings, and external environment of complex human behavior within organizations (Marion, 2003, p. 195). Modern leadership and management also have to look toward results, respecting the qualities of each individual, with a

desire to help each individual grow, achieve, and fulfill potential. This perspective describes leadership as facilitating cooperative behavior, providing opportunities for personal growth, and addressing human needs (Gutek, 2002, p. 118). Similarly, Bolman and Deal (2003) explained that “The job of the leader is support and empower. Support takes a variety of forms: showing concern for people, listening to their aspirations and goals, and communicating personal warmth and openness” (p. 324). Modern organizational theories suggest that there is a relationship between organizations and human behavior, whereby interactions and relationships among individuals and the group within the organization influence behavior.

As most scholars agree, leadership is a complicated and expansive subject. In the literature on leadership and management, there are thousands of sources offering theoretical and practical insights. Most theories provide the same common framework for rules, laws, and principles. The practical aspects can be categorized by behavioral and personality styles. Theory and practice are the guiding principles for leadership. The classical scholars (Henri Fayol, Max Weber, and Fredrick Taylor) suggested a single best system, but most modern theorists believe there is no single best way to organize (Marion, 2002, p. 24).

Theories have impacted on modern management and leader practices

Based on Marion’s (2002) topology, modern leadership and management are impacted by Closed Systems theory, Open Systems theory, and Anti-Positivism. Specific theories include Machine Theory, Human Relations Theory, Structuralism Theory, Contingency Theory, Strategic Choice Theory, Population Ecology Theory, Culture Theory, Critical Theory, Institutionalism Theory, and Complexity Theory. All of these theories have profound effects on management and leader practices. They seem to agree on the strength of human behavior and its effects on leadership and management styles.

Closed Systems Theory is a combination of Machine Theory, Human Relations Theory, and Structuralism Theory. These theories focus on efficiency and effectiveness and are based on the presumption that organizations are largely self-contained entities, unaffected by external environmental forces. The advocates of this theory argue that decisions can be optimized, and that there is one best solution to a given problem (Marion, 2002, p. 27). Machine Theory focuses on hierarchical communication, excluding horizontal communication. Bureaucracy Theory is modeled around the organization's efficiency needs. This theory is related to Human Relations Theory in that human variability is controlled by rules. This approach conveys that systems are independent of environmental influences.

In contrast, Open Systems Theory simply holds that organizations are strongly influenced by their internal behavior and external environment. The internal behaviors of an organization refer to the activities, interactions, and sentiments of the participants. Seiler (1967) argues that a system's external environment comprises human forces, organizational forces, and technologies (Marion, 2002, p. 91). Human forces characterize population density, available skills, attitudes, cultural values, etc. Organizational forces characterize theories of organization, political requirements, competition, etc. Technological forces characterize available techniques and knowledge, finances and markets, materials and supplies, etc. (Marion, 2002, p. 93). Open Systems theorists suggest that organizational subsystems interact in complex ways with one another and with their environment. The environment also provides key resources that sustain organization and lead to change and survival.

As Marion (2002) describes, modern theories of organization are rooted in Open Systems Theory. Specific theories include Contingency Theory, Strategic Choice Theory, Population Ecology Theory, Culture Theory, Critical Theory, Institutionalism Theory, and Complexity

Theory. Although there is a great variety in the perspectives provided, they share the view that an organization's survival depends on its relationship with the environment.

Fred Fielder (1973) is considered the father of Leadership Contingency. Contingency Theory explains that group performance results from the interaction of two factors. These factors are known as leadership style and situational favorability. This theory suggests that an organization is structured in ways that best fit the environment in which it is embedded. Contingency theorists argue that, rather than seeking universal principles that apply to all or most organizations, analysts should identify contingency principles that reflect the demands of the particular types of task environments in which organizations operate (Marion, 2002, p. 134). An example of contingency thinking is the insight that bureaucracy is an organizational model that applies better to stable task environments than to volatile and uncertain ones. With respect to leadership and management, Fiedler (1973) suggests that a leader's effectiveness is determined by the degree of match between a leader's dominant trait and the situation's favorableness to the leader (Marion, 2002, p. 137). This suggests that the organization is effective when it is in tune with its contingent conditions and ineffective when it is out of tune with them. All else being equal, if an environment is stable and predictable, leaders can put together a rather simple organizational structure (Marion, 2002, p. 121).

Strategic Choice Theory assumes that leadership and management have significant choice over how they manage and adapt to changes in their external and internal environments. A changing external environment prompts leaders to adjust their idiosyncratic preferences—personal and impersonal forces. Strategic Choice theorists argue that decision-making is based on making adjustments to these factors, with the range of options well thought out, filtered, and constrained by values, beliefs, experiences, and leadership styles (Marion, 2002, p. 166).

Population Ecology Theory concerns adaptive preferences that respond to the stochastic forces of natural selection. This suggests that leadership and management need to develop routines to ensure reliability and accountability. Reliability and accountability require organizational structures that are highly reproducible. These reproductions of routines cause organizational inertia. Inertia is considered a consequence of selection. A balance is found at the niche's "carrying capacity" (Marion, 2002, p. 196).

Culture Theory states that its premise is increased effectiveness through strong cultures and engaged participants. O'Reilly and Chatman (1996) define culture as a "system of shared values and norms that define appropriate attitudes and behaviors for organizational members 'how to feel and behave'" (p. 160). They, like many researchers, see a relationship between culture and performance/attainment of organizational goals. As Marion (2002) has pointed out, "culture is not just ethnic or national. It is any stable order that emerges from interactive, social dynamics. When people interact, they influence each other's beliefs, understandings, behaviors, and perceptions of reality" (p. 225). Understanding differences between cultural values and work values, and between the organizational values of different groups at work, can be helpful when trying to implement change. This knowledge can also be helpful when developing culturally appropriate leadership and management practices.

Critical Theory is about control preferences and organizational control that can have a profound effect on people. Critical theorists argue that even the more humanistic approaches to management subjugate workers to the interests of rule elite. They suggest that leadership and management need to devise strategies for effectively controlling workers and enhancing their productivity. However, Critical Theory remains somewhat on the fringe of organizational theory because of its radical leaning (Marion, 2002, p. 254).

Institutional Theory is about social preferences. Institutional theorists see organizations as a means by which societal values and beliefs are embedded in organizational structure and expressed in organizational change (Marion, 2002, p. 228). Schein (1992) stated, “climate is the feeling that is conveyed in a group by the physical layout and the way in which members of the organization interact with each other, with customers, or with other outsiders” (Marion, 2002, p. 9). Leadership and Management seek to understand how cultural differences influence organizational patterns.

Chaos and Complexity Theories describe complex interactions involving large networks. Chaos is the general theory of interacting systems, while Complexity is derived from Chaos Theory, and is a specific theory of interactive and adaptive systems (Marion, 2002, p. 303).

Complexity Theory explains non-linear, dynamical systems. Most of nature is nonlinear and not easily predicted. For example, weather comprises many components that interact in complex ways, leading to unpredictability. Ecosystems, embryos, and the brain are other examples of complex, dynamical systems that are not easily explained by linear chains of causality (Marion, 2002, p. 304). However, applying Complexity Theory to the understanding of social organizations challenges the assumptions of linear relationships between contingencies and organizational structure and focuses on unpredictability and uncertainty in organizational behaviors.

Systems Theory suggests that leaders are designers, stewards, and coaches. In terms of organizational leadership, they need to view the organization as a system in which the parts are internally connected and externally connected to the external environment and clarify how the whole system can work better. In practice, leaders are responsible for building organizations, such as the design of the organization’s policies, strategies, and “systems”. From this

perspective, organizational leaders provide structures and integrate vision, mission, values, and goals. Leaders are responsible for designing the organization and empowering people throughout it to keep it running. In addition, they need to provide new skills of mentoring, coaching, and helping others to grow and become a new cadre of leaders, in addition to problem-solving and decision-making (Marion, 2002, pp. 313-314).

Create new/effective leadership teams

Of all the organizational theories described in this paper, it is clear that there is no single best theory for creating effective leadership teams. Similarly, there is no leadership style that is best suited for all organizations; rather, it depends on the organizational culture. Most theories address the formal structure, internal workings, and external environment of complex human behavior within organizations. The practical aspects can be categorized by behavioral and personality styles. Nevertheless, modern leadership and management literature suggests that the leadership role has shifted from a group-leadership concept to one that emphasizes teamwork and empowerment. Effective leadership teams focus on their team members, as team leaders who direct, coordinate, and control the work of others have been replaced by coaches, counselors, and facilitators. When creating effective leadership teams, the team leader must understand the team's intended purpose. By extension, it is critical that prior to creating leadership teams, the team leader must first understand the existing organizational culture.

Effective leadership teams are about team building. By definition, a team is a group of two or more entities linked by a common bond to achieve a shared goal. To operate effectively with teams, organizations must know how to create, use, and sustain them and their members.

Team building is essentially about finding the right people and designing an appropriate structure. It is important to note at this stage that creating and leading an effective team lies with

the team leader. First, the team leader is the team's designer. Second, the team leader determines the team's composition, structure, and members' roles. Third, the team leader develops the team's work processes and how team members will work together.

Bolman and Deal (2003) posed the following question as a guide for team building: What are we trying to accomplish? What needs to be done? Who should do what? How should we make decisions? Who is in charge? How do we coordinate efforts? What do individual members care about most: time, quality, and participation? What are the special skills and talents of each group member? What is the relationship between this group and others? How will we determine success? (Bolman & Deal, 2003, p. 96)

In shaping leadership teams, it is essential that the team leader understand the teamwork processes, including goals, roles, procedures, and interactions. The goal is the value-added work that each team can and should perform. The team needs to define the role each member, including the team leader, is expected to play and the requirements they must meet. The procedure is the mechanisms by which the teams do their work when they are together. The interaction is the patterns of behavior and operating principles.

After answering these questions and these concerns, the team leader should be better prepared to start developing leadership teams. The process of creating leadership teams includes identification, recruitment, and selection of leadership team members. Leadership team members provide leadership for the organization and help carry out its mission. They are people who have personal characteristics likely to lead to their success within the organization. Completing a position description with specific responsibilities, expectations, accountabilities, and scope of authority is critical and is a good first step. In recruiting candidates to leadership teams, the leadership should consider the following criteria: 1) academic training; 2)

employment history; 3) leadership skills; 4) cultural fit; 5) reputation; and 6) references. This process identifies the leadership style that fits the organization culture and other leadership team members. Contingency Theory can be used to select “best fit” leadership team members for leadership teams.

Once leadership teams are in place, the team leader needs to teach, coach, mentor, set expectations, and determine clear accountabilities for all leadership team members. Members should know exactly what is expected of them, and why they have been selected to the team. This opportunity is also to inform new leadership teams of the organization's goals and how teams will make those goals a reality. At this stage, the team leader may want to provide additional training in areas such as team building, organizational development, and multicultural diversity.

The next step in building effective leadership teams is to improve human resource management. Bolman and Deal (2003) suggested the following principles and practices:

1. Build and implement an HRM strategy: Develop a shared philosophy for managing people, build systems and practices to implement the philosophy
2. Hire the right people: Know what you want and be selective
3. Keep them: Reward well, protect jobs, promote from within, share the wealth
4. Invest in them: Invest in learning, create development opportunities
5. Empower them: Provide information and support, encourage autonomy and participation, redesign work, foster self-managing teams, promote egalitarianism
6. Promote diversity: Be explicit and consistent about the organization’s diversity philosophy, hold managers accountable

(Bolman & Deal, 2003, p. 136)

These principles and practices essentially state that organizations and people need each other to succeed. Similarly, it takes cooperative teamwork efforts to be successful.

The challenge to team effectiveness is the imbalance of power within teams that creates a volatile dynamic and complicates teamwork. Issues such as conflict are inevitable in the team environment. The effective way to address this concern is to create a policy team that addresses team dynamics and sets the policy and strategy for communications, information sharing, and building understanding.

All in all, creating effective leadership teams requires integrating team building and human resource management and establishing policies to address ongoing team dynamics. In addition, effective leadership teams communicate a clear mission and strategy, lead by example, set demanding yet realistic goals, maintain an open, communicative management style, and practice clear, careful strategic management. Finally, empowering people is vital to the team's success by fostering communication and collaboration throughout the team.

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